Wk 5 - Summative Assessment: Written Communication Article and Email

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APMT/460: Cyber Communications

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Week 5 – Fake News Story Cyber Communications Resolution

In April 2025, a viral claim circulated on social media alleging that 17 people had gone missing in Atlanta after attending job interviews arranged through Indeed, a job searching website. The story went viral and began raising alarms after one TikTok user warned viewers to be cautious when applying for jobs online. However, the claim lacked verifiable evidence. The Atlanta Police department confirmed that although people had been reported missing the previous week, non-matched the story's specifics. Indeed, also released a PSA stating that they had not received any official reports and found no evidence to support the claims. Additionally, no credible news outlets reported on the alleged disappearances. The details of the story varied widely across users. Some mentioned teenagers, others didn't specify ages, and job details remained vague. Further doubt was based on the story's accuracy when it was discovered that an image of missing children was being reused and traced back to 2019 (Christensen, 2025).

This story proved to be considered fake for several reasons. Let’s start with the lack of verifiable evidence. Neither the Atlanta Police Department nor any credible news outlets confirmed that 17 people had gone missing after job interviews through Indeed. There were also a handful of inconsistent details. The posts circulating on social media garnering the attention of the masses and cause concern gave conflicting information around the profiles of the missing people. We could also include the fact that no reports to authorities were made, old content was being misused, and no credible sources were reporting on this story.

Recently, our organization has been linked to contributing to circulation of this fake news and the alleged incident involving job interviews and missing individuals. We want to be clear: these claims are entirely unverified and inaccurate. Currently, no credible law enforcement agency or investigative source has provided any evidence to support these allegations. This is a sensitive situation as we are now attached to spreading this false information. We want to handle this incident with the highest of care to maintain our integrity, professionalism, and trust with the public's perception of our organization.

We acknowledge that the unintentional involvement in spreading misinformation may have amplified fear or confusion. That is why we are taking the following immediate actions to reinforce our commitment to ethical communication and responsible information sharing. Starting with our digital channels, we have issued a formal correction to state clearly that the claims are unverified and unsupported by law enforcement or credible sources. Additionally, we have included links to reputable fact-checking organizations and are re-distributing our internal guidelines for evaluating news before sharing it.

We are also conducting a thorough internal review to understand how to better ensure that our content approval process mitigates breakdowns in approvals and ensures accountability at every level of communication. Enhanced training for all staff involved in content creation and distribution will continue to be an ongoing priority for our organization. We'll be evaluating our social media policy to ensure it includes specific safeguards to prevent the spread of unverified information in a way that is clear and free from ambiguity for our employees to follow. According to Wardle and Derakhshan (2017), combating misinformation requires both organization accountability and media literacy education to reduce its impact and prevent recurrence. This dual approach ensures both short term correction and long-term sustainable prevention.

We are committed to updating the public on the outcomes of our review and the steps taken to safeguard against future incidents. This is a continuous practice we intent to uphold and are committed to be being good stewards of authentic information. We deeply regret any roles we played in the spread of a story that lacked substantial factual evidence. We are thankful to have a community that holds us accountable and continues to give us the opportunity to build and earn their trust. We are committed to learning and improving every day to be an organization that is dependable, ethical, and trustworthy. You can always count on us to do the right thing, even if it’s not the easy thing, and uphold ethical integrity.

We believe in learning from this moment and moving forward better equipped to protect and inform our community.

Email to CEO

Subject: Addressing Misinformation Situation and Strengthening Internal Protocols

Hello Jonas,

I've provided an overview of our response to the recent misinformation incident that our organization has been connected to. I've also provided some recommendations for strategies that can be used in the future to improve the company's cyber communication practices.

Response to Misinformation

A prompt factual statement has been released across all digital communication channels to address the false claims that were linked to our organization. The article released addressed the false claims and provided transparency on what we're doing to address this internal oversight. Additionally, we reiterated that we are a trusted ethical brand that operates with integrity and will continue to uphold this standard.

Proposed Communication Strategies

1. Implement ongoing media literacy training.

- To empower and enable our employees to critically asses and provide factual content, I recommend instituting regular media literacy training.
- This training could help foster a workplace culture equipped to identify and mitigating misinformation and navigating the complex media landscape we're up against.
- As highlighted in the article Media Literacy in the Workplace: Why It Matters and How to Improve It," integrating media literacy into business operations enables companies to navigate the media environment with agility and oversight ensures communication strategies are both effective and ethically sound.

2. Establish a structured content approval process.

- Introducing a structured content approval workflow will ensure that all external communications undergo thorough review for accuracy, consistency, and alignment with our brand values.
- This process could minimize the risk of sharing false information and maintain the integrity of our brand position and messaging.
- According to subject matter experts in the field of content, a detailed approval process helps companies maintain their brain identity, ensures accuracy and consistency in messaging, and protects their reputation.

By adopting these strategies, we can be more effective in our communication and uphold the trust and integrity of our organization.

Please know, we are actively working to diffuse the current situation and look to your leadership to support ongoing media literacy efforts and reinforce robust approval processes for external communications.

Thank you!

Jaime

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